

ESSAY

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The Relevance of Rabindranath Tagore in the Twenty-First Century

একুশ শতকে রবীন্দ্রনাথ ঠাকুরের প্রাসঙ্গিকতা

English translation of the Bengali original

Introduction

There are moments in world history when a new technology or a political transformation places before humanity questions that prevailing habits of thought cannot answer. The twenty-first century is exactly such a juncture. Artificial intelligence, big data, aggressive nationalism, religious fundamentalism, environmental catastrophe, and a crisis in the very meaning of the human have risen up together. The revolution in information technology has thrown human freedom, equality, and human identity into an unprecedented crisis.

These crises may seem new, but at their root lie perennial questions: how much freedom does a person truly have, how should power be arranged, what is the purpose of education, and where lies the relationship between religion and humanity. Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941) asked these questions all his life. The philosophy that took shape across his poetry, novels, plays, essays, and educational work speaks deeply to every one of the twenty-first century's crises. This essay analyses Tagore's relevance against the backdrop of some of the century's central crises.

The Crisis of Freedom and Equality

What does freedom mean in the age of big data?

In the twenty-first century the crisis of freedom is not as overt as the autocratic rule of earlier ages. It is invisible, silent, and therefore far more dangerous. Technology companies such as Google, Facebook, and Amazon gather every click, every search, every moment of every user, and by analysing that data they influence the decisions that shape people's futures. The Israeli historian Yuval Noah Harari has warned that big-data algorithms could create a digital autocracy in which all power is concentrated in the hands of a small elite, and most people become not merely victims of exploitation but wholly irrelevant.

At the heart of liberal democracy lies the belief that a person has a free will within, and that on the basis of that will they make the decisions that govern their life and society. But if an algorithm decides who is shown which information and which opinions they will come to hold, how real is "free will"? Here the very foundation of liberal politics collapses.

The files leaked by Edward Snowden proved that even Western democratic states keep the communications of millions of citizens under surveillance (Greenwald, 2014). In the 2016 Cambridge Analytica scandal it was shown that Facebook data could be used to manipulate the political opinions of millions of voters.

Tagore identified freedom as the most fundamental characteristic of human existence. In his famous poem he dreamed of a heaven "where the mind is without fear and the head is held high," where a person can think, speak, and act without fear (Tagore, 1910). In today's age of surveillance this dream is even more relevant, because in a society where a person knows that their every step is being recorded, they can never think in complete freedom.

In his play Tasher Desh (The Land of Cards) Tagore showed how an institution turns human beings into machines of blind obedience (Tagore, 1933). This image of the religious institution of his time applies equally to today's algorithms. The algorithm suppresses the very impulse to question, because it is always ready to supply the "next content." The society depicted in Tasher Desh, where everyone moves as directed and no one thinks for themselves, can be read as a metaphor for today's "filter bubble" and "echo chamber" (Tagore, 1933; Pariser, 2011).

Tagore's educational philosophy placed extraordinary emphasis on critical thinking. At Santiniketan he wanted students not to accept anything blindly but to question for themselves (Tagore, 1915). Today's digital-literacy movement says exactly this: people must be taught to verify information, to question its sources, and to apply their own judgement (Hobbs, 2010). Tagore was a pioneer of this education.

The central image of his play Muktaghara is relevant here too. The autocrat's machine seeks to hold back the free current of the waterfall, but that dam finally breaks and the soul's cry for liberation sounds out (Tagore, 1922). The digital surveillance of the twenty-first century is a modern form of that dam. It controls the flow of information and constrains the freedom of human thought. Tagore's philosophy is an inspiration to break that dam.

Equality dissolving in the ownership of data

Data is the most important resource of the twenty-first century. Just as the country that owned coal and iron mines in the nineteenth century led the industrial revolution, in the twenty-first

century whichever company or country owns vast quantities of data will sit at the centre of power.

The inequality of the industrial revolution lay in the ownership of the means of production; the inequality of the digital revolution lies in the ownership of data. The difference is that those excluded from the coal mines could at least create value with their labour, but if artificial intelligence, in the digital economy, replaces even human labour, then nothing remains to give the excluded.

According to Oxfam's 2026 report, in 2025 the total wealth of the world's billionaires reached a historic high of 18.3 trillion dollars, having grown by 2.5 trillion dollars in a single year — roughly equal to the total wealth of the poorer half of humanity, some 4.1 billion people. At the same time nearly half the world's population lives below the poverty line, and this inequality is steadily widening (Oxfam, 2026).

In the context of Bangladesh this inequality is even sharper. The wide gap in access to digital services between city and village, rich and poor, educated and uneducated, is known as the digital divide (Warschauer, 2003). Those on the wrong side of this divide are deprived not only of technology's benefits but are increasingly cut off from economic opportunity as well.

Tagore was not merely theoretical on the question of social inequality; he tried to confront it in practice. In the Bengal countryside he established agricultural cooperatives and set up systems of easy-terms credit to rescue peasants from the exploitation of moneylenders (Mukhopadhyay, 1960). Behind this cooperative movement lay his deep conviction that genuine development comes from the bottom up, through the growth of ordinary people's capabilities, not through plans imposed from above (Tagore, 1904). The Nobel-winning economist Amartya Sen's "capability approach" — that development means the expansion of human capabilities, not merely the growth of income — has its roots in Tagore's thought (Sen, 1999).

The Crisis of Work

The rapid advance of artificial intelligence has stirred an unprecedented storm in the labour market of the twenty-first century. In many fields AI is becoming faster and more reliable than human beings. According to the World Economic Forum's 2025 Future of Jobs report, 41 percent of employers worldwide plan to reduce their workforce over the next five years because of

artificial intelligence. According to the International Monetary Fund's 2024 assessment, nearly 40 percent of jobs worldwide are exposed to artificial intelligence; in advanced economies that figure reaches 60 percent (IMF, 2024; WEF, 2025).

The pace of this change is so rapid that the prevailing system of education cannot keep up with it. What a child learns today may be largely irrelevant by the time they enter working life. The most important skill of the twenty-first century is the skill of learning — the capacity to remake oneself continually in a constantly changing environment (Harari, 2018). But the present education system still depends mainly on memorising information and acquiring specific competencies, and is not at all prepared for this new reality.

Tagore's educational philosophy offers the most relevant answer to this crisis of work. His critique of the prevailing education system is even truer today. In his essay *Shikshar Herpher* (The Vagaries of Education) he wrote that the school turns the child into a vessel stuffed with information but destroys their curiosity, creativity, and power of independent thought (Tagore, 1892). This critique is even more relevant now, because artificial intelligence can memorise information far better than a human being. What remains distinctively human is creativity, critical thinking, and human connection.

The pedagogy Tagore introduced at Santiniketan aligns strikingly with today's "twenty-first-century skills" movement: learning in nature, the integration of art with science, the development of each student's distinct talent, and acquaintance with diverse cultures. All of this is close to what today's educationists advocate. The successful education systems of Finland and Singapore have a deep affinity with the Santiniketan model (Sahlberg, 2011).

Tagore saw work as something beyond mere livelihood — a medium of self-expression and self-realisation. In his idea of karma-yoga, work becomes meaningful only when the person's creativity and soul are engaged in it (Tagore, 1909). When artificial intelligence takes over repetitive tasks, this opportunity will open before human beings: to do only the work that requires genuine human creativity. In Tagore's vision this is a real possibility, provided the right system of education is in place.

The Crisis of Nationalism

In many countries the politics of "my country first" is gaining popularity, while institutions of global cooperation — the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, climate agreements — grow weaker.

Tagore was one of the most far-sighted critics of aggressive nationalism. His book *Nationalism* was published in 1917, amid the devastation of the First World War, and in it he warned that when nationalism rises above humanity it does irreparable harm (Tagore, 1917). Written more than a hundred years ago, that warning is equally relevant today.

Tagore drew an important distinction between nationalism and love of country. To love one's country and to work for its people is noble. But to think one's own nation supreme and to hate or despise other nations is dangerous (Tagore, 1917). He believed that human identity does not end at a single level; a person is at once a member of their family, a resident of their village, a citizen of their country, and a part of universal humanity.

Behind his founding of Visva-Bharati lay this philosophy of universal humanity. "Where you commune with the world" — through communion with the world a person becomes whole (Tagore, 1912). At Visva-Bharati there was provision for studying the arts, philosophy, and cultures of many countries, and an effort to bring Eastern heritage into conversation with Western knowledge. This idea of intercultural dialogue is the most essential foundation of today's global cooperation.

When Religion Becomes a Weapon

In the twenty-first century religion is passing through a new and dangerous transformation. Religion is no longer merely a matter of an individual's spiritual practice; it has become a weapon of state power. In many countries political leaders use religious identity to consolidate their own power, manufacture hatred against minorities, and brand rational discourse as blasphemy. Hindu nationalism in India, Islamic fundamentalism in the Middle East, Christian nationalism in America — in every case religion is being used for a particular sectarian interest in place of universal humanity (Juergensmeyer, 2017).

The most terrible outcome of this religious politics is communal violence. The killing of the Rohingya in Myanmar, communal riots in India, Shia–Sunni conflict in the Middle East — all

prove that when religion is mixed with ethnic or political identity, it becomes profoundly destructive (Appleby, 2000).

Tagore was not the representative of any particular religious community; he sought a universal human spirituality that unites people of all faiths (Tagore, 1910). In his *Gitanjali*, God is found not in any temple or mosque; He is found in the peasant's field, in the dust of the path, in the voice and joy of ordinary people.

In his famous poem he wrote that when a person goes to seek God outside, God dwells among people, beside the labouring poor (Tagore, 1910). This human-centred religious philosophy is the most powerful resistance to turning religion into a political weapon. A religion that brings people close to people cannot be used against people.

His play *Achalayatan* is a fierce protest against the blind obedience of institutional religion (Tagore, 1912). *Achalayatan* is the religious institution where a centuries-old rule can be questioned by no one, and whoever questions is punished. This image maps directly onto today's religious fundamentalism. Fundamentalism always fears the question, because to question is to claim the right to question, and that right weakens the foundation of fundamentalist power.

During the 1905 partition of Bengal, when Tagore organised the Rakhi-bandhan festival, he had Hindus and Muslims of both communities tie rakhis on one another, establishing a symbol of unbreakable unity (Mukhopadhyay, 1960). This initiative was a cultural programme to consciously transcend religious division. In the twenty-first century, when social media is used to spread communal incitement, Tagore's strategy of cultural bridge-building is more relevant than ever.

Across Tagore's whole life and philosophy one idea returns again and again: a religion that teaches people to distrust other people can never be anything but a weapon of violence. Against religious violence, this is the most powerful ethical stance.

Tagore in the Post-Truth Age

"Post-truth" is one of the most dangerous phenomena of the twenty-first century. The capacity to spread false information, fake news, and planned disinformation is now greater than at any time, and once it spreads, proving it false is extremely difficult. On social media a false report spreads

six times faster than a true one (Vosoughi et al., 2018). Because false news generally provokes anger, fear, and surprise, people share it in the grip of that emotion, without verifying. Deepfake technology has made the problem still more complex: it is now possible to make videos in which real people appear to say things they never said (Chesney & Citron, 2019).

In Bangladesh the spread of rumour and false information has become a life-threatening crisis, acting as a principal driver of every episode from the July–August 2024 mass uprising to the December 2025 attacks on leading media houses. According to recent data from DismisLab and Rumor Scanner, over the past year the volume of false information has not only grown by 58 percent; nearly 52 percent of it is spread through video, and a notable share using artificial intelligence (AI). This planned disinformation, alongside its incitement of communal violence, became a cause of the deaths of 173 people in mob lynchings in 2024 — proof that in Bangladesh "post-truth" reality is no longer a theoretical debate but an acute threat to national security and to life itself.

Tagore regarded the pursuit of truth as one of the highest duties of human life. In his essay on truth he said that surrender to falsehood weakens a person not only intellectually but morally (Tagore, 1908). For him the refusal of truth was not merely a matter of intellectual values; it was a spiritual duty, because he believed that the ultimate truth is itself the divine.

In his novel *Char Adhyay* (Four Chapters) we see how a noble aim, once it takes the path of falsehood and violence, ends in horror (Tagore, 1934). Against false propaganda and violence carried out in the name of revolution, this novel is a powerful moral statement. In the twenty-first century, when political parties use false information to achieve their ends, Tagore's ethical stance is intensely relevant.

In his educational philosophy Tagore laid particular stress on reason and evidence-based thinking. At Santiniketan he wanted students not to believe anything with their eyes closed but to question and verify for themselves (Tagore, 1915). This critical thinking is the most effective safeguard against post-truth. Today's media-literacy education teaches people to verify information, to question sources, and to avoid the traps of the algorithm — a modern form of Tagore's educational philosophy (Hobbs, 2010).

In his play *Raja O Rani* (The King and the Queen) we see how a falsehood spreads poison through a kingdom, and how in the light of truth that poison is cured (Tagore, 1889). This image applies to today's age of fake news and disinformation. In a society where a falsehood takes institutional form, the most effective path to truth is to expose that falsehood through literature and culture.

In his essay *Atmashakti* (Self-Power) he wrote that a nation's greatest strength is its heritage of truthfulness, and that a nation which takes refuge in falsehood grows weak over time (Tagore, 1905). The politics of post-truth in the twenty-first century is leading precisely toward that weakness. Tagore's philosophy of truthfulness is the most effective ethical basis for arresting that decline.

The Crisis of Education in the Age of Artificial Intelligence

The prevailing education system was built mainly for the age of the industrial revolution, when the aim was to produce people who could work in factories, follow fixed rules, and work all their lives in a stable profession. But in the twenty-first century this model has become wholly ineffective. By the time today's child reaches the age of 2050, the world will have changed so much that most of what is taught today may be irrelevant. So what should children be taught today?

According to Harari, the four core skills that should be at the centre of twenty-first-century education are critical thinking, creativity, collaboration, and communication. To these must be added psychological resilience — the capacity to remake oneself in the face of change without breaking down (Harari, 2018). But most education systems still depend on memorising information and scoring in examinations. According to the World Economic Forum's report, 65 percent of the world's primary-school children will enter jobs that do not yet exist today.

The crisis of Bangladesh's education system is the local expression of this global crisis. In an examination-centred system, students who score GPA-5 often prove unable to solve the real problems of life. The spread of coaching centres, the tendency to leak question papers, and the absence of creative education all prove that Bangladesh's education system is not ready for the twenty-first century.

Tagore gave the answer to this crisis more than a hundred years ago, when the crisis was not yet so clear. In his essay *Shikshar Herpher* (1892) he said that the prevailing education destroys the child's life-force, turning them into a vessel that holds information rather than a thinking human being (Tagore, 1892). This critique applies against today's education system too.

The first principle of Tagore's educational philosophy was joyful education. He believed that education given amid fear and pressure never endures; true education comes from curiosity and joy (Tagore, 1915). Teaching under the trees at Santiniketan, celebrating the festivals of the seasons, and the integration of art, music, and dance were the practical form of that philosophy. Modern research in education shows that in a joyful environment students' rate of learning and capacity for retention are markedly higher (Fredrickson, 2001).

His second principle was the connection of education with nature. Tagore believed that education confined within four walls cuts the child off from real life (Tagore, 1915). Learning amid nature teaches the child to observe, to ask questions, and to find their own answers. Today's idea of experiential learning is a modern form of Tagore's method (Kolb, 1984).

His third principle was the harmony of mother-tongue education with a global outlook. Tagore argued all his life for education in the mother tongue. He showed that education in a foreign language wastes half a child's intellectual energy on the language itself and cuts them off from their own culture (Tagore, 1892). At the same time his global vision is embodied in the very name *Visva-Bharati*. He wanted students to be rooted in their own culture while connecting with world culture (Tagore, 1912). In the twenty-first century, this balance between local identity and global citizenship is an essential skill.

The Crisis of Community and Human Connection

Platforms such as Facebook speak of building "community," but these digital communities cannot take the place of genuine human connection. For a human being does not merely exchange information; a person feels touch, meets eye to eye, sits together, and consoles another through physical presence.

Since the industrial revolution, family, neighbourhood, religious community, and professional associations have grown steadily weaker, and people have become steadily more isolated. In the twenty-first century this isolation has taken an extreme form. Research shows that people

increasingly report themselves lonely, as if in a global epidemic (Cigna, 2020). The health damage of loneliness has been shown in research to equal smoking fifteen cigarettes a day (Holt-Lunstad et al., 2015).

Research also shows that excessive use of social-media platforms in fact increases loneliness and depression (Twenge et al., 2018), because digital communication cannot provide the depth and warmth of real human connection. The COVID-19 pandemic made this truth still clearer. Even with the convenience of virtual communication during lockdown, people were deeply harmed by the absence of real social connection (Pancani et al., 2021).

In Tagore's philosophy the human being is never complete alone. A person discovers themselves through relationship with others. His famous line "the joy is in this very seeking of the path" speaks of the joy of the journey of relationship, in which he found the meaning of life in the walking of the path rather than in reaching the destination (Tagore, 1916).

In his short story *Kabuliwala*, the deep human bond drawn between an Afghan fruit-seller and a little Bengali girl — a father-and-daughter relationship — transcends the boundaries of religion, language, and culture (Tagore, 1892). In the fragmented world of the twenty-first century this story sends a powerful message: to build human connection one needs neither the same religion nor the same language, only the mutual recognition of a shared humanity.

The community Tagore built at Santiniketan is relevant as an alternative model. There students did not merely study; they lived together, celebrated festivals together, walked together in nature, and built deep relationships with one another (Tagore, 1915). In this model, education and community were not separate. Education was itself a communal experience. Today, when virtual education is gaining popularity, the Santiniketan model is a powerful alternative perspective.

Tagore's Philosophy of Nature: A Moral Basis for Climate Justice

Tagore's philosophy of nature is not merely a poetic sense of beauty but a deep ethical and philosophical position, one that laid the ground for climate justice long before today's climate movement. For him nature was a living being, a partner in human life, and a manifestation of the ultimate reality (Tagore, 1916).

His play *Prakritir Pratishodh* (Nature's Revenge) expresses this vision most clearly (Tagore, 1884). In the play a sannyasi rejects nature and wishes to live in the realm of intellect alone, and nature takes its revenge, draining him of life-force. This image is the most precise forecast of today's environmental crisis. Industrial civilisation made exactly this error: treating nature as something to be conquered, it severed its relationship with nature, and now faces that revenge.

Tagore saw the human being not as the "owner" of nature but as a "part" of it. This view aligns with the deep-ecology movement of today's environmental philosophy (Naess, 1973). Deep ecology holds that nature has an intrinsic value independent of its usefulness to human beings. Tagore understood this truth naturally, and in his poetry he presented the river, the rain, the cloud, and the bird — each element of nature — as an autonomous presence.

Bangladesh's relationship with the river, in Tagore's life, was not merely geographical but deeply personal and spiritual. Living at Shilaidaha on the banks of the Padma, he wrote some of the finest work of his life. In his poem *Sonar Tari* (The Golden Boat) the great waters of the Padma and an island ringed with fields of paddy are drawn — an image that can become a symbol of today's climate refugees. The farmer is left alone; the golden boat sails away carrying his harvest (Tagore, 1894). In today's reality the Padma is drying, salinity is rising, and coastal farmers are losing their land. The river Tagore loved, on whose bank he sat and wrote Bangladesh's national anthem, "Amar Sonar Bangla" — that golden Bengal is today among the first victims of climate change.

The central claim of climate justice is that those who caused the harm must bear the responsibility, and those who have been harmed have the right to compensation (Shue, 1992). The foundation of this ethical claim lies in Tagore's humanist philosophy. He said again and again that the powerful have a duty toward the weak, and that this is not a matter of charity but of moral obligation (Tagore, 1917).

In his book *Nationalism* he showed how Western industrial civilisation colonised Asia and Africa, plundered their resources, and built its own prosperity on that plunder (Tagore, 1917). In the context of twenty-first-century climate change, this analysis takes on a new dimension. The wealthy countries "colonised" the atmosphere through their industrialisation, emitting carbon, and countries like Bangladesh bear the cost of that colonisation. Tagore's anti-colonial ethical stance is therefore directly connected to the demand for climate justice. He said that prosperity

built on the harm of others is not progress but decline (Tagore, 1917); in the matter of climate change this saying applies exactly.

At Santiniketan he began the annual festival of Vriksharopan (tree-planting), in which students planted trees and tended them. He believed that planting a tree is a spiritual act, one that requires thinking of future generations (Mukhopadhyay, 1960). In his educational philosophy, a child who grows up in the midst of nature grows up with a sense of responsibility toward it (Tagore, 1915). This is the most effective model for today's climate education.

The Reality of War in the Twenty-First Century

At this moment several armed conflicts are being fought simultaneously in several corners of the world, filling the headlines of the international press every day. These wars bring humanity's deepest questions to the fore.

The Iran–United States–Israel war is at this moment the world's most dangerous conflict. Iran's ambassador has said that more than fifteen hundred civilians have so far been killed. Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz has created a global energy crisis.

The Ukraine–Russia war has continued since February 2022. The war in Gaza has continued since October 2023. The civil war in Sudan has continued since April 2023. In each of these wars civilians — especially children and women — are the worst affected. In every conflict religious, ethnic, or political identity is used as a weapon. Modern technology such as drones, cyber weapons, and artificial intelligence has made war still more merciless and far-reaching (Roff, 2014). And in every case international institutions, including the United Nations, have proved helpless to stop the fighting.

Tagore did not see war merely as a political failure; he saw it as the gravest crime against humanity. The First World War (1914–18) cast a deep shadow over his life. His hope in European civilisation was shattered by the barbarity of that war. In his book *Nationalism* he wrote that aggressive nationalism and the greed for power are the root cause of this destruction (Tagore, 1917).

Today, when a bomb is dropped on a country's children in their school, Tagore's question rises anew: in the name of what civilisation is this being done? In his essay *Sabhyatar Sankat* (Crisis

in Civilization, 1941) he wrote that the material progress of Western civilisation is no proof of moral advance. A civilisation that kills children is, in the truest sense, in decline (Tagore, 1941).

Tagore knew that war does not merely kill the body; it erodes the human spirit within. His play Raktakarabi (Red Oleanders) protests against the machine-civilisation that turns human beings into numbers, and it applies to today's wars too, where child deaths are reduced to a statistic called "collateral damage" (Tagore, 1926).

Tagore's idea of the "universal human" (vishwamanav) is the most relevant philosophical position in the war-torn world of the twenty-first century. He believed that national borders cannot break the fundamental unity of humankind. The child of Iran, the mother of Palestine, the farmer of Ukraine, and the refugee of Sudan are all members of the same human family (Tagore, 1917). This vision is the most powerful moral resistance to today's rhetoric of "us versus them."

Tagore's Final Message, Still Relevant Today

In 1941, lying on his deathbed and watching the devastation of the Second World War unfold, Tagore wrote his last prose work, Sabhyatar Sankat (Crisis in Civilization). In it he said, "To lose faith in humanity is a sin." Even amid the threat of atomic weapons, the arrogance of power, and the frenzy of nationalism, he kept his faith in humanity (Tagore, 1941).

Today, in 2026, when smoke rises over the sky of Tehran, when the children of Gaza play on heaps of rubble, when the sound of shelling does not cease on the fields of Ukraine, and when people in the refugee camps of Sudan pass their days in uncertainty, what path is left before humankind other than to hold fast to this faith of Tagore's?

War ends, but the question of humanity does not end. Tagore reminds us that as long as one human being can recognise the human dignity of another, resistance to war will endure.